Week 25

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 7 · LESSON 1

Evil

BIG IDEA

Evil isn't something God made; it is the absence of good, the way darkness is the absence of light, and it entered our world when people chose to push God out. The very fact that we can call something evil points to a standard of good beyond us, and so to God.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Before you start, pray for yourself, your students and your leaders: these weeks on evil and suffering may bring real pain, hurt and doubt to the surface.
2. Evil is approached two ways over the coming weeks, philosophical (more academic) and pastoral. Be patient: not every student will connect with both.
3. Evil is not a force God created. It is a privation of good, like darkness without light or cold without heat: remove God's goodness and evil is what's left.
4. Since the garden, people chose to remove God and be their own moral compass. God graciously gave us free will, and evil was the result of that choice.
5. Storyteller idea: someone who got lost. A compass only works if it points to something outside you; God is that external moral compass.
6. If there were no God, there would be no good to measure evil against. Evil exists, so a standard of good exists, which suggests God exists.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Who in my group might be carrying real pain into these weeks, and how will I pray for them by name?
2. Where am I tempted to be my own moral compass instead of looking to God?
3. How will I keep track of hard questions I table so none of them get quietly dropped?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. How would you explain the idea that evil is the absence of good, not a thing God made?
2. Where have you seen evil or suffering up close, and what questions did it leave you with?
3. What happens when people use themselves as their own moral compass? What examples come to mind?
4. Why might the existence of evil point toward God rather than away from him?
5. What questions about suffering would you most want answered in the next few weeks?

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WEEK 25 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Take a breath and pray

0:06 I want you to take a second and just take a deep breath. We are going to be talking about evil and pain and suffering. This may seem like it's just another lesson in the full gamut of lessons, and you may be tired. The year is coming to an end, and this is going to take some tenacity to get through. I want you to pray, and I want you to pray for the next four weeks for your students. Not that you haven't been already, but if it's been hit or miss, I want you to really dial in on prayer this coming week and in these next couple of weeks.

0:54 Not only do you probably have students who are coming along and maybe are on the verge of making some decisions — I pray that that is the case — but you also have students who are going to have some significant questions, doubts, pain and hurt brought up these next few weeks. I want you to be aware of that before we even get started: we're going to dive into some pretty deep and some pretty heavy things over the next couple of weeks. I want you to be ready for it. So as you prepare for this week's discussion on evil, I want you to be prayerful for yourself, for your students and for your leaders.

Two approaches to evil

1:37 When we're talking about evil, we're actually talking about two different approaches to how we talk about evil, and throughout the next couple of weeks we're going to look at both of these approaches. I want you to be patient, because there are two different ways that we can do this. There is what we call — what I call — the philosophical. Why can't I spell? We'll just call it that. The second is the pastoral approach. Now, the philosophical approach is sort of academic, and the pastoral approach is just what it is: it's pastoral.

2:13 So we're going to look at it from both sides. I want you to make sure that you understand that at the starting gate, so you don't jump the gun. It's important that we see it from both sides, but not every student is going to respond to it from both sides, which is why we do it this particular way.

What evil actually is

2:31 In this first lesson, we want students to really understand what evil is. Evil is the opposite of good. It's the opposite of God. A lot of people will sort of assert that evil is this thing that maybe God created — that maybe God did something where, as part of the whole created universe, there is this force called evil, and it's the opposite of good: good's a thing and evil's a thing. But evil is the absence of good. It's a privation of good. It's sort of the same thing as darkness. We don't have a measurement for darkness; the measurement is light, and darkness is what we call the absence of light.

3:13 The same thing works for cold and heat. We don't have a measurement for cold. We have a measurement for the absence of heat, and that's what we call cold. We call it the absence of heat; we call it cold. It's just how we describe it. Evil is the same way. You remove God from the picture, you remove his goodness from the picture, and suddenly you have what we would call evil. So, very philosophically and kind of heady, the idea is that evil is this sort of other-than-God-ness out there that humanity is responsible for. And we're responsible since the garden, because we actually allowed evil to permeate our world by making the wrong choice. We made a choice to remove God from the picture.

4:04 So evil is a stark, dark reminder that we've lost our way — that we've looked to ourselves for our own moral compass, that we've told God we've got this figured out and we don't need him. So, being the gracious God that he is, he said: you have free will. You can do what you want. You can choose to go your own way. So we did. And evil was the result of that choice.

The compass illustration

4:32 One way I think your students can really grasp this idea is through the storyteller. You want someone who can tell a great story about being lost. For some of them, it might not be too hard to find someone who has been lost but didn't use navigation. We all have. I don't remember the last time I actually got lost, because all I have to do is plug it into here. But what if you had to navigate by the sun or by a compass?

5:00 So you have north, and then you have south, and you have west, and you have east. How do I know if I need to head east? How do I know which way is east? Well, the only way in which I know where east is is if I know where north is. So the first thing you do when you're lost and you have a compass, or you can look at the sun, is figure out where north is. Once you find what's called magnetic north, then you can orient yourself and you can figure out every other direction.

5:37 Well, imagine if the compass just kept being pointed back to you. What would you do? You'd just be walking in circles, trying to figure out where you're supposed to go. You'd never be able to find east or west or south, for that matter. It has to be something external of you, something that's not you, to do that. So God serves as that moral compass.

Evil points to God

6:03 So what that leads us to conclude — and this is where the philosophical piece comes in — is that the very fact that evil exists suggests that God exists. Think of it this way. If there is no good, then there is no evil. If there's no God, there's no good. If there's no good, there's no evil. And if there's no good, then there's no evil — which means there's nothing to compare it to. The only way in which we understand what evil is is because we have good, because we can look at evil and say, that's not good.

6:36 So if that doesn't exist, then God doesn't exist. But there is evil. Therefore, there's good. Therefore, there's the standard to which we compare good and evil. Therefore, God exists — that's kind of how that works. Hopefully that made sense. So from a philosophical standpoint,

the very existence of evil suggests that God exists, because we have a standard by which we can understand what evil actually is.

Small group time

7:06 Okay, so, small group time. You're going to get questions, and it's going to get real, real fast. This is the point where students are going to start bringing up probably a load of questions on you, like, well, why does God allow suffering? Why does God allow good people to suffer? Why do bad things happen to good people? And any other variation of the question that basically says, why is there evil and suffering? Some of it you can probably answer as it relates to evil specifically. Some of it you may want to table. But be careful how you table a question. Make sure you write it down — in your leader's guide, your discussion guide, or wherever you have to — so you can come back to it and so you don't ignore the question.

7:47 But there are going to be a lot of questions. And if you're not getting a lot of questions, your students still have the questions. So I would suggest posing them yourself. Ask them the questions that they're probably asking you. So if no one says, why has God allowed suffering? Or why has God allowed good people to suffer? Why has God allowed a child to die? Why has God allowed a lot of things that we kind of look at and go, oh my gosh, what an injustice, what a terrible thing? You ask it, and see what they think. But be ready, because this is going to start getting very, very personal and very deep for some students, especially if they have experienced any kind of evil or suffering in their lives.